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JUBILATION: (From left) Bindra with coach Buhlmann, in Beijing, his parents in Chandigarh

WHEN HE FIRED HIS LAST SHOT IN BEIJING, BINDRA WONDERED IF A SHOOTOUT WOULD BE NEEDED. COACH BUHLMANN WHISPERED IN HIS EAR, "YOU ARE THE FIRST. GOLD."

Exhausted after missing out on a medal in Athens, crushed because he produced a nine rather than consistent tens, Bindra was asked by concerned relatives if he wanted something to eat. Even then he replied, "No, I'm busy digesting my nines."

Later that day Buhlmann, who was working with another Italian shooter, found that the wooden floor panel under Bindra's shooting station had come loose, feeling like a trampoline underfoot. The Italian shooter was allowed to move the station two feet to the left, from where she won silver. A few weeks after his event, Bindra told this story to a few people but asked for it to be kept secret. He didn't want to become another name in the litany of hard-luck stories that litter Indian sport.

Before leaving for Beijing, Bindra talked to INDIA TODAY at length from his training base in Germany. He sounded half-weary, half-wise, part-philosopher, part-pessimist. "I don't care about anything. I just want to shoot." Oh, but he cares too much about how he shoots. After Athens, he had not been able to sleep for five days. He was 22 and his hair had gone grey. He made rifle-shooting sound like manual labour, breaking boulders on a highway in the desert.

This is a boy born in privilege to a

family that adored him and gave him his own air-conditioned shooting range at home. He didn't need to strive for anything or to suffer for it, but for shooting, he does. He'd done enough, won enough, could stop any time and become some bitch-n-moan specialist. Why didn't he just throw it away? Bindra paused. "It's hard, you know," he said, "it's hard to give it away. When you want to, or you think you want to, something stops you."

Personal pride probably stops him, that driven voice inside that tells him every time, I can do this, dammit, I can nail it. In a sport where the margin for error is zero and the difference between shooting well and winning is, "hairline", he wants to be as flawless as is possible. In a competition final, there is no perfect score, the best a shooter can do is 10.9; so just how many times can you go there, to the dizzy edge of perfection? Well, on his last shot in Beijing, Bindra produced a 10.8, which is pretty darn close.

When the medal came, it was claimed by everyone: Hungarian reporters at the press conference asked Bindra about the Hungarian Laszlo Szucsak, who used to coach him before

he switched to Buhlmann. German TV wanted time with him because he trains near Dortmund and uses a Walther rifle. High-profile US swimmer Dara Torres' Meridian stretching team in Beijing sat up and got in touch when they heard that the Indian boy with the bad back had actually cleaned up gold. That day his story shared the podium with the record-busting Michael Phelps.

Before Beijing, Bindra had talked eloquently about what happens to an athlete after he arrives at the destination he has worked towards for years. When it's over he said, "The first moments are always filled with emptiness. There's nothing to do. Then you sit down and set new goals for yourself."

In the Games village, India's only Olympic champion was walking towards a hastily arranged press conference by IOA chief Suresh Kalmadi who was at badminton during the men's 10m air rifle final. Drained and ready to go home, Bindra turned to a friend by his side and wondered, "*Ab main kya karoonga?* (what will I do now?)"

After an Olympic gold medal, what new goals can there possibly be for this sombre, smart, funny boy? Hey, perhaps, he could start with growing that hair.

with Ramesh Vinayak